

WOLGAWURZELN

GENEALOGY OF THE GERMANS FROM RUSSIA



SAMPLE DOCUMENT

INDIVIDUAL RESEARCH SCHÄFER

INTERIM REPORT · BLOCK 1

Where did the family come from before 1766? Four entries in Norka,
two confirmed villages in Isenburg: what three hours of research have
established and how to proceed

Norka · Oranienbaum · Lübeck · Büdingen · Wolf · Burgbracht

Block 1 · 3 hours

Prepared for the Schäfer family

September 2026

WOLGAWURZELN.DE

THE ASSIGNMENT

QUESTION AND APPROACH

The origin report assigned the surname Schäfer to the colony of Norka and documented the origin “Isenburg”. It left open from which entry of the 1767 list the family descends and which village that ancestor came from. That is the task of this research.

STARTING POINT

The family knows its line back to Konrad Schäfer*, born about 1845 in Norka; the grandfather Heinrich Schäfer* was born there in 1912.¹ The founding list of Norka gives the name Schäfer four times in 1767, each time with Isenburg as origin; so far the villages of Wolf and Burg bracht are confirmed.^{2,3} Between 1767 and 1845 lie three generations without names.

THREE QUESTIONS

- | | |
|-------------|---|
| 1 · ENTRY | From which of the four Schäfer entries of 1767 does the line descend? |
| 2 · VILLAGE | Which village in the Isenburg territories did this ancestor come from? |
| 3 · ROUTE | On which ship and in which transport group did he reach Norka in 1766/67? |

AGREEMENT

Block 1 covers three hours at a fixed price, this report included. Every further block is proposed in advance with its scope and hours and begins only after approval. Archive fees arise only after consultation.

WORK LOG BLOCK 1

STEP	SOURCE	TIME
Review of the family's documents and the origin report	Records, recollections ¹	0:20
Analysis of the four Schäfer entries of 1767: given names, heads of household, places of origin	First settlers list after Pleve ^{2,3}	0:40
Transport groups and ships of the Norka settlers in 1766	Kulberg lists, ship lists ⁴	0:30
Assembly point Büdingen: sources on the 1766 marriages and literature	Decker 2009 ⁵	0:30
Church book sources, reading sample, register format	Archion, church archives ^{7,8}	0:40
Report		0:20
Total		3:00

Persons marked with an asterisk are fictitious. This document is a sample: the Schäfer* family is invented, while all sources, lists, places, archives and work steps are real. The church book entry of 1720 is a real entry from a real register.

CHAPTER 1

THE FOUR SCHÄFER ENTRIES OF 1767

The list with which Norka begins is a count taken after arrival. It names households, not families, and gives the origin as the clerk understood it.

The count at the end of 1767 lists 218 households with heads, members, ages, denomination and origin.^{2 3} The name Schäfer appears four times, twice with a woman as head of household. That was not unusual in 1767: of the 26,676 people sent to Saratov, 3,293 died on the way according to Pleve, almost one in eight; often the widow then carried on the household.⁴

ENTRY	HEAD AND MEMBERS	ORIGIN PER LIST	CONFIRMED PLACE	ASSESSMENT
no. 22	Johannes Schäfer, Henriette Julianna Schäfer	Isenburg	open	Married couple; first candidate
no. 37	Apollonia Schäfer	Isenburg	Wolf	Woman as head; a candidate if sons lived in the household
no. 80	Margaretha Schäfer	Isenburg	open	as no. 37
no. 191a	Johann Heinrich Schäfer	Isenburg	Burgbracht	Single man, listed right after the Kaiser household from Burgbracht; second candidate

Origin per list from the 1766 ship lists and the 1767 census; confirmed place from church or civil records; as given on [norkarusia.info](#).^{2 3}

The key is the 1798 census. It counts Norka household by household with the names and ages of all members; through them the families of 1798 can be linked to the entries of 1767, which shows who could have produced a Konrad Schäfer* around 1845. The census is published and will be analyzed in Block 2.⁹

WHAT “ISENBURG” MEANS

In 1766 Isenburg was divided into several lines, Büdingen, Meerholz, Wächtersbach and the principality of Birstein; the clerks often noted only the ruler. Confirmed places of origin of Norka settlers include Büdingen, Wolf, Burgbracht, Kefenrod, Schlierbach, Lorbach and Birstein.² The two Schäfer villages show the difference: Wolf, today part of the town of Büdingen, belonged to the county of Isenburg Büdingen; Burgbracht, today part of Kefenrod, lay in the district of Wenings of the principality of Isenburg Birstein.¹⁰

FINDINGS

DOCUMENTED Four Schäfer entries in 1767 with Isenburg as origin; confirmed Wolf (no. 37) and Burgbracht (no. 191a).^{2 3} Losses on the journey according to Pleve.⁴

PROBABLE The line descends from no. 22 or no. 191a, the two entries with a man of this name.

OPEN The link through the 1798 census; the home village of no. 22.

CHAPTER 2

THE ROUTE IN 1766

Anyone leaving Isenburg for the Volga in 1766 went through Büdingen. The town was assembly point and departure point at once, and it kept records.

Count Gustav Friedrich of Ysenburg tolerated the Russian recruiters in his residence town. In St. Mary's Church in Büdingen 375 colonist couples were married between 24 February and 8 July 1766, many of them shortly before departure.⁵ For the question of the village this marriage register is the most important source, as it gives the place of origin for many couples.

From Lübeck the ships crossed the Baltic to Kronstadt, and boats took the emigrants on to Oranienbaum, where titular counselor Ivan Kulberg drew up a list for every ship: arrival date, port, ship, captain and the colonists with their families.⁴ Most of the later Norka settlers arrived on 19 July 1766 on the Novaya Dvinka, the Slon and the Fortitudo, others on 28 and 29 July on the Vologda, the Strelna and the Apollo.² After the oath of allegiance they traveled in groups of 600 to 1,000 people to Saratov and reached the Norka river on 15 August 1767.²



Sketch map: Büdingen as assembly point, the Isenburg residences of Meerholz, Wächtersbach and Birstein, and Altenhaßlau in the county of Hanau. Locations rounded.

WHAT THE KULBERG LISTS CAN SHOW

According to the published lists, 22,711 colonists arrived at Oranienbaum in 1766, about three quarters of all Volga colonists.⁴ The Schäfer entries are very probably on these six ships. The ship entry is older than the count of 1767 and shows the family as it went on board in Lübeck: with the husband, if he was still alive, and with the children. Checking the six lists is part of the next block.

FINDINGS

DOCUMENTED	Büdingen as assembly point, 375 marriages in 1766. ⁵ Ships and arrival dates of the Norka groups. ² Content and scope of the Kulberg lists. ⁴
PROBABLE	The family traveled with one of the two Norka groups of 19 or 28 July 1766.
OPEN	Ship, household size and ages of the Schäfer entries in the Kulberg lists; a marriage in Büdingen in 1766.

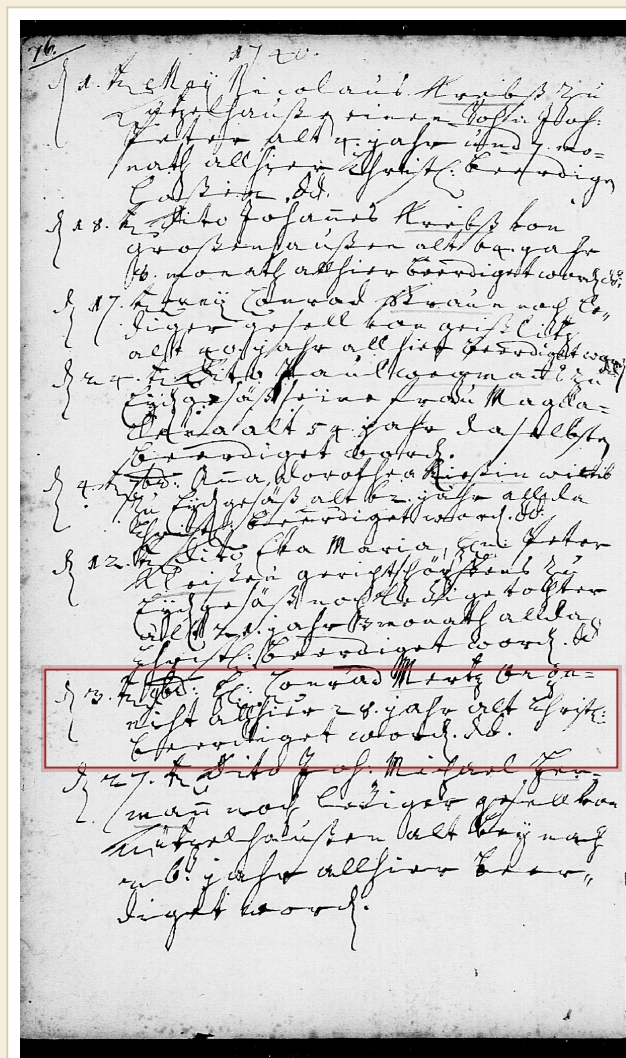
Once the lists of 1766 and 1767 name the village, the way leads into the church books. There the family's baptisms, marriages and burials before emigration are recorded, in Kurrent script, without an index, page by page.

The church books of the Wetterau belong today to the Protestant Church in Hesse and Nassau, those of the Kinzig valley in the former county of Hanau to the Protestant Church of Kurhessen Waldeck; a large part of both holdings can be read online on the Archion portal.⁷⁸ For the Schäfer* family two registers come first: the Büdingen marriage register for 1766 and the church books of the parishes of Burgbracht and Wolf, the two confirmed places of origin.²⁵ The work always runs the same way: year by year, page by page, every entry is read, every hit recorded with image, page and wording, every miss as well, so that an exclusion can be checked later.

On the right is a page from the burial register of the Reformed congregation of Altenhaßlau in the county of Hanau, about twelve kilometers south of Büdingen, year 1720.⁸ The Isenburg registers of the same years look similar: the same Kurrent hand, the same formulas, the same brevity. The marked entry is transcribed word for word on the next page.

What such a page yields: date, name, status or occupation, age, sometimes the place of residence in the village. What it does not yield: parents and cause of death. To trace a family back three generations you therefore need all three kinds of register, baptisms, marriages and burials, read against each other.

This page holds eight burials from four months. For the years 1720 to 1766 of a single village that makes well over a hundred pages, and as many again for baptisms. This is why register work is billed by the hour and scoped in advance.

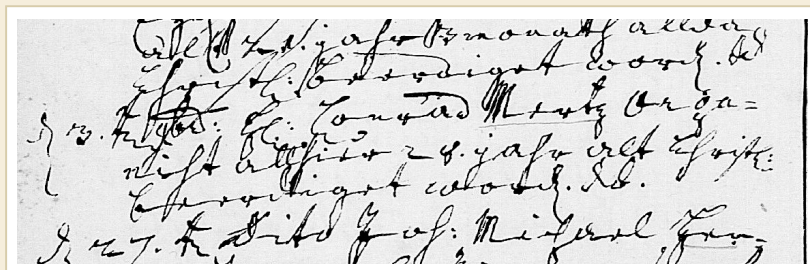


*Burials 1720, page 76. Landeskirchliches Archiv Kurhessen
Waldeck, church book Altenhaffslau Reformed 1653 to 1771,
image 1269, via Archion.*

CHAPTER 3 · CONTINUED

THE ENTRY, WORD BY WORD

Three lines, one life: an organist, 28 years old, buried in August 1720. This is what the work on a single entry looks like.



Detail of the same page. Landeskirchliches Archiv Kurhessen Waldeck, church book Altenhaußlau Reformed 1653 to 1771, image 1269, via Archion.

TRANSCRIPTION

d. 3. Augst: Joh: Conrad Mertz Orga=
nist allhier 28. jahr alt christl:
beerdiget worden. dd.

READING AID

IN THE ORIGINAL	READING	EXPLANATION
d. 3. Augst:	den 3. August, on 3 August	“d.” for “den”, month abbreviated; whether “3.” or “13.” is settled by comparing the digits on the page.
Joh: Conrad Mertz	Johann Conrad Mertz	“Joh:” is the usual abbreviation.
Orga= / nist allhier	Organist allhier, organist here	The double stroke marks a word broken at the line end; “allhier” means in this parish.
28. jahr alt	28 Jahre alt, 28 years old	The age stands in for the date of birth, accurate to a year or two.
christl: beerdiget worden	christlich beerdigt, given a Christian burial	Fixed formula of the register for a regular burial.
dd.	open	Clerk’s abbreviation at the end of several entries, not yet explained.

FINDINGS

DOCUMENTED	Reading of the entry of 3 August 1720 with name, office, age and formula. ⁸
PROBABLE	The day as “3.”, not “13.”, based on comparing the digits on the page.
OPEN	The abbreviation “dd.”. The entry serves as a reading sample; it has no connection to the Schäfer* family.

CHAPTER 4

LISTS, LITERATURE AND LETTERS

Besides the church books there are three routes to an emigrant's origin: the printed lists, the analysis of the Büdingen marriages of 1766, and the records of the ruling house.

Printed lists. In 1972 Karl Stumpp recorded the emigrants to Russia with place of origin and destination colony, as far as his sources allowed; the comparison with the Norka Schäfer entries is planned for Block 2.⁶ For the Hanau part of the Kinzig valley there is the Hessian emigrants database at LAGIS Hessen; how far it covers Isenburg will be checked at the same time.¹¹

Büdingen. Klaus Peter Decker has analyzed the Büdingen marriages of 1766 and linked them to the colonies.⁵ Comparing the 375 couples with the Schäfer entries is the fastest route to the village and comes first in the next block.

Letters. The records of the county of Isenburg Büdingen are held in the princely archive in Büdingen; a request for emigration files and lists of subjects from 1766 has been prepared and will be sent only after approval, since archives may charge fees. For the Hanau area the State Archive in Marburg is responsible; its finding aids can be searched online via Arcinsys.¹²

WHAT HAS BEEN CHECKED AND WHAT REMAINS OPEN

SOURCE	STATUS AFTER BLOCK 1	RESULT
Norka first settlers list 1767	analyzed	four entries, origin Isenburg, Wolf and Burgbracht confirmed
Kulberg lists 1766	ships and dates of the Norka groups identified	checking the six ship lists open
Büdingen marriage register 1766 (Decker)	source available	comparison of the 375 couples open
1798 census of Norka	source available	linking the entries open
Church books of Burgbracht, Wolf and Büdingen	responsibility and access clarified	register work open
Princely archive Büdingen	request prepared	to be sent after approval

FINDINGS

DOCUMENTED Holdings, responsibilities and access routes of the sources named.^{5 6 7 11 12}

PROBABLE The village can be determined through the Büdingen marriage register of 1766 or the Kulberg lists, without archive fees.

OPEN All hits concerning the family itself; they are the subject of Block 2.

RESULTS

STATUS AFTER BLOCK 1 AND RECOMMENDATION

The entries documented

Four times Schäfer in Norka in 1767, all from Isenburg; Johannes (no. 22) and Johann Heinrich (no. 191a) as candidates for the line; Wolf is confirmed for no. 37 and Burgbracht for no. 191a.

The route documented

Assembly point Büdingen with 375 marriages in 1766; most of the later Norka settlers reached Oranienbaum on 19 and 28 July 1766 on six ships known by name.

The sources for the village documented

Büdingen marriage register 1766, Kulberg lists, 1798 census, church books of Burgbracht, Wolf and Büdingen via Archion, princely archive Büdingen: all extant, all accessible.

The family itself open

No entry about the family was read in Block 1; the three hours went into analyzing the lists and clarifying the sources.

RECOMMENDATION FOR BLOCK 2

Four hours are enough to answer the three questions with high probability, without archive fees. Order by yield: first the sources that can name the village, then the register work.

STEP	SOURCE	EXPECTED RESULT	TIME
Comparison of the 375 Büdingen marriages and the entries in Stumpp with the four entries	Decker 2009 ⁵ , Stumpp 1972 ⁶	Home village of the couple Johannes and Henriette Julianna	1:00
Checking the six ship lists of the Norka groups	Kulberg lists ⁴	Ship, household size, ages	0:30
Linking the four entries to the 1798 census	1798 census ⁹	Children and grandchildren; decision between no. 22 and no. 191a	0:30
Register work, baptisms 1720 to 1766: Burgbracht for no. 191a, the village found for no. 22	Church books via Archion ⁷	Baptism of the emigrant, parents, siblings	1:30
Request to the princely archive Büdingen	Letter	Emigration files 1766, only after approval	0:30
Block 2			4:00

Block 2 at 50 € per hour, paid in advance, billed by actual time, unused time refunded, starting only after approval. Archive fees are stated in advance. Should the village be settled after the first step, the remaining time goes into register work.

APPENDIX

SOURCES

1. Information from the Schäfer* family (sample): copy of the grandfather's birth record, 1912, Norka; Origin Report Schäfer, Wolgawurzeln, September 2026.
2. norkarussia.info, Norka, a German Colony in Russia (Steve Schreiber): Founders (households of 1767, origin from the 1766 ship lists and the 1767 census, confirmed places from church and civil records), Voyage to Russia 1766, Ship Transport 1766, Journey 1766 to 1767; accessed September 2026.
3. Igor Pleve: Einwanderung in das Wolgagebiet 1764 bis 1767. Göttinger Arbeitskreis, several volumes from 1999 (first settlers lists of the mother colonies).
4. Kulberg lists: Igor Pleve, Lists of Colonists to Russia in 1766, Saratov 2010; Andreas Idt and Georg Rauschenbach, Die Kuhlberg Listen, Moscow 2024; overview at volgagermans.org (22,711 colonists in 1766); losses on the journey according to Pleve, as given on norkarussia.info.
5. Klaus Peter Decker: Büdingen als Sammelplatz der Auswanderung an die Wolga 1766. Büdingen 2009 (375 marriages in St. Mary's Church from 24 February to 8 July 1766).
6. Karl Stumpp: Die Auswanderung aus Deutschland nach Rußland in den Jahren 1763 bis 1862. Tübingen 1972.
7. Archion, church book portal of the Protestant churches in Germany, archion.de; Protestant Church in Hesse and Nassau, central archive Darmstadt.
8. Landeskirchliches Archiv der Evangelischen Kirche von Kurhessen Waldeck, Kassel: church book Altenhaßlau Reformed 1653 to 1771, burials 1720, page 76, image 1269, viewed via Archion in September 2026.
9. Brent Alan Mai (ed.): 1798 Census of the German Colonies along the Volga, Lincoln 1999; The 1775 and 1798 Censuses of the German Colony on the Volga, Norka, AHSGR 1995.
10. Articles "Wolf (Büdingen)" and "Burgbracht", German Wikipedia: Wolf part of Büdingen since 1971; Burgbracht part of Kefenrod, 256 inhabitants in 2022, in 1787 in the district of Wenings of the principality of Isenburg Birstein; accessed September 2026.
11. LAGIS Hessen, historical information system of Hesse, database Hessische Auswanderer and historical gazetteer, entry Amt Altenhaßlau (Altenhaßlau, Eidengesäß, Geislitz, Großenhausen, Lützelhausen, 1787); accessed September 2026.
12. Hessian State Archive Marburg, finding aids via Arcinsys Hessen; article "Amt Altenhaßlau", German Wikipedia (county of Hanau Münzenberg, part of Hesse Kassel from 1736).

Note. The interim report lists every source checked with its result, even when negative, so that the family can follow every step and look up every entry themselves. Supporting scans are delivered with the report as an appendix. In this sample the family is fictitious; the church book entry of 1720 is real.

WOLGAWURZELN

RESEARCH FOR YOUR FAMILY

This document is a sample. An origin report or a family history for your own family begins with a free first assessment: you send the surname and, if known, the village or region, and you learn what can be found before any cost arises.

ORIGIN REPORT

39 € one time

- one surname
- assignment to the colony
- history of the colony
- the family's migration route
- PDF in 3 to 5 days

FAMILY HISTORY

69 € one time

- up to four surnames
- origin of every line
- a narrated history
- map and timeline
- PDF in 5 to 8 days

INDIVIDUAL RESEARCH

149 € for 3 hours

- ancestors with names and dates
- requests to archives in Germany and Russia
- report included
- further hours only after your approval

Both reports are also available as a printed photo book for 29 €, shipping within Germany included. All fees are final prices; no VAT is charged under § 19 UStG. Transcriptions of old handwriting are quoted after the scans have been reviewed.

HOW IT WORKS

1 · FIRST ASSESSMENT

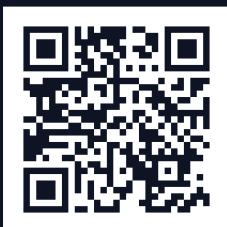
Surname and, if known, village or region, by WhatsApp or email. Reply usually within 24 hours: what can be found, which route makes sense, what it costs. Free of charge.

2 · ORDER

Order with the surname and what you already know. Before the research begins, names and details are reviewed together so that nothing fails because of a spelling variant.

3 · DELIVERY

The report arrives as a PDF with sources, map and timeline. The invoice comes with the report. On request also printed as a photo book.



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Replies usually within 24 hours, in German, Russian or English.